Chapter 0

"When the rain never ends, someone has to walk through it."

On the twenty-third day of September, the rain began to fall.

At first, nobody thought much of it. The weather stations had predicted a storm, and the people went about their lives beneath umbrellas and raincoats, waiting for the skies to clear.

But the skies never cleared.

Day became night, and night became morning. The rain continued to fall upon the cities, the forests, the mountains, and the oceans. Rivers overflowed their banks. Streets disappeared beneath rising water. Entire towns were abandoned as the relentless downpour turned ordinary life into an exhausting struggle for survival.

Then, on the twelfth day, the first creature appeared.

It was discovered in the flooded basement of an abandoned shopping center, a pale, many-limbed thing that moved through the water without making a sound. Its body resembled that of an insect, yet its head was unmistakably mammalian. When the recovery team approached, it vanished into a drainage tunnel too narrow for a human to enter.

Three days later, something emerged from a rain-soaked forest and attacked a village.

It was followed by more sightings.

Creatures appeared wherever the rain fell. Some were small enough to hide beneath abandoned vehicles. Others towered above buildings, their silhouettes visible through the curtains of falling water. A few seemed almost animalistic, hunting anything that moved. Others watched human settlements from a distance, standing motionless beneath the rain as if waiting for something.

And then people began disappearing.

The authorities called it a biological catastrophe. Scientists proposed theories involving unknown organisms, atmospheric contamination, and an ecological collapse unlike anything recorded in history.

None of their explanations lasted long.

Because the creatures were not simply appearing in the rain.

They were appearing in places where they had never existed before.

Some were discovered inside sealed buildings. Others emerged from the middle of flooded streets. One was reportedly seen crawling out of a perfectly dry room moments after rain began striking the windows.

The world had no answers.

And the rain showed no signs of stopping.

By the end of the second month, entire regions had become inaccessible. Communication networks failed across vast stretches of land, emergency services were overwhelmed, and governments began withdrawing personnel from the most dangerous areas.

Millions of people remained trapped in places no rescue team could safely reach.

Humanity had spent centuries learning how to survive natural disasters.

It had never prepared for a disaster that seemed to create its own monsters.

That was when the Rainwalker Initiative was established.

The Rainwalkers were a specialized rescue and reconnaissance unit created to enter the storm zones, evacuate survivors, recover vital information, and investigate the origin of the phenomenon. Their equipment combined reinforced waterproof armor, environmental sensors, portable communications systems, and weapons designed to protect them against hostile lifeforms.

Their mission was simple to describe.

Surviving it was another matter entirely.

Every expedition meant stepping into a world where visibility could fall to a few meters, familiar streets became deadly waterways, and something might be watching from behind every curtain of rain.

Some Rainwalkers never returned.

Others came back with injuries that no medical examination could adequately explain.

A few returned claiming they had heard voices beneath the sound of the storm.

Their reports were dismissed as exhaustion.

At least, officially.

Among the Rainwalkers, there was a saying:

If you hear something calling your name in the rain, keep walking.

Nobody knew who had said it first.

Nobody wanted to find out why.

For Mara Veyne, however, the rain was not a mystery she could afford to ignore.

Before joining the Rainwalkers, she had spent weeks searching for her younger brother, who had disappeared during the evacuation of their hometown. The last message she had received from him contained only three words.

The rain is watching.

His location had never been recovered.

His name remained on the missing persons list, buried among thousands of others.

Mara joined the Rainwalkers because they were the only people still willing to go where he had vanished.

She told herself that she was looking for answers.

She told her commanding officer that she was prepared for anything.

But on her first deployment, as her team entered a district that had been submerged for nearly four months, she discovered something that made every report, every theory, and every warning suddenly feel insignificant.

The rain stopped.

Not across the world.

Not even across the entire district.

Just around them.

For several seconds, a perfect circle of silence surrounded the team. Water hung motionless in the air. Ripples froze across the flooded streets. Even the drops falling from the edges of their helmets seemed suspended in place.

Then Mara's radio crackled.

A voice emerged through the static.

A voice she had not heard since the day her brother disappeared.

"Mara?"

She stopped walking.

Her teammates turned toward her.

The voice came again, faint and distorted, as if traveling from an impossibly distant place.

"Don't let them find the source."

Then the rain resumed.

And somewhere beneath the flooded city, something enormous began to move.

Mara stared into the darkness beyond her flashlight.

For the first time since the rain began, she understood that the Rainwalkers might have been searching for the wrong thing all along.

Perhaps the creatures were not invading their world.

Perhaps the rain was opening a door.

And perhaps something on the other side had finally noticed them.

The mission had only just begun.